(Link: www.nhs.uk/)

Food poisoning

Food poisoning is rarely serious and usually gets better within a week. You can normally treat yourself or your child at home.

Symptoms of food poisoning

Symptoms of food poisoning include:

- feeling sick or being sick
- diarrhoea
- tummy pain
- a high temperature
- feeling generally unwell

The symptoms usually start within a few hours or a few days of eating food that caused the infection.

Sometimes symptoms do not start for a few weeks.

How to treat food poisoning yourself

If you or your child have food poisoning, you can usually treat it at home.

The symptoms usually get better within a week.

Diarrhoea and vomiting can usually be treated at home. The most important thing is to have lots of fluids to avoid dehydration.

Do

- ✓ stay at home and get plenty of rest
- ✓ drink lots of fluids, such as water or squash – take small sips if you feel sick
- ✓ carry on breast or bottle feeding your baby – if they're being sick, try giving small feeds more often than usual
- ✓ give babies on formula or solid foods small sips of water between feeds
- ✓ eat when you feel able to – it may help to avoid foods that are fatty or spicy
- ✓ take paracetamol (Link: www.nhs.uk/medicines/paracetamol-for-adults/) if you're in discomfort – check the leaflet before giving it to your child

Don’t

- do not have fruit juice or fizzy drinks – they can make diarrhoea worse
- do not make baby formula weaker – use it at its usual strength
- do not give children under 12 medicine to stop diarrhoea
- do not give aspirin to children under 16

A pharmacist can help with food poisoning

Speak to a pharmacist if:

- you or your child (over 5 years) have signs of dehydration (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/dehydration/), such as dark, smelly pee or peeing less than usual
- you're an older person, have a weakened immune system, or have other health conditions that increase your risk of dehydration
- you need to stop diarrhoea for a few hours

They may recommend:

- oral rehydration powder that you mix with water to make a drink
- medicine to stop diarrhoea for a few hours, like loperamide (Link: www.nhs.uk/medicines/loperamide/) (not suitable for children under 12)

Find a pharmacy (Link: https://www.nhs.uk/service-search/find-a-pharmacy)

Call 111 now if:

- you're worried about a baby under 12 months
- your child stops breast or bottle feeding while they're ill
- a child under 5 years has signs of dehydration (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/dehydration/), such as fewer wet nappies
- you or your child (aged 5 years or over) still have signs of dehydration after using oral rehydration sachets
- you or your child keep being sick and cannot keep fluid down
- you or your child have bloody diarrhoea or bleeding from the bottom
- you or your child have diarrhoea for more than 7 days or vomiting for more than 2 days

111 will tell you what to do. They can arrange a phone call from a nurse or doctor if you need one.

Call 999 or go to A&E if you or your child:

- vomit blood or have vomit that looks like ground coffee
- have green vomit (adults)
- have yellow-green or green vomit (children)
- may have swallowed something poisonous
- have a stiff neck and pain when looking at bright lights
- have a sudden, severe headache
- have a sudden, severe tummy ache
- have blue, grey, pale or blotchy skin, lips or tongue - on brown or black skin this may be easier to see on the palms of the hands or soles of the feet
- are having severe difficulty breathing, or taking lots of quick, short breaths
- are confused or not responding as usual

What we mean by severe pain

Severe pain:	• always there and so bad it's hard to think or talk • you cannot sleep • it's very hard to move, get out of bed, go to the bathroom, wash or dress
Moderate pain:	• always there • makes it hard to concentrate or sleep • you can manage to get up, wash or dress
Mild pain:	• comes and goes • is annoying but does not stop you doing daily activities

Find your nearest A&E (Link: https://www.nhs.uk/service-search/find-an-accident-and-emergency-service/)

Do not drive to A&E. Ask someone to drive you or call 999 and ask for an ambulance.

Bring any medicines you take with you.

How you get food poisoning

Food poisoning is caused by eating something that has been contaminated with germs.

This can happen if food is:

- not cooked or reheated thoroughly
- not stored correctly – for example, it's not been frozen or chilled
- left out for too long
- handled by someone who's ill or has not washed their hands
- eaten after its "use by" date

Any type of food can cause food poisoning.

Infections that cause food poisoning

Food poisoning is usually caused by:

- campylobacter bacteria – the most common cause of food poisoning in the UK
- salmonella bacteria
- E. coli bacteria
- norovirus (vomiting bug) (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/norovirus/)

More information

Find out more about food hygiene at home from the Food Standards Agency on the GOV.UK website (Link: https://www.gov.uk/health-and-social-care/food-hygiene-at-home)

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